Topic vocabulary: Quality

A Circle the correct word. If both are correct, circle both.

1 The procedure's good, but I think we can **better / streamline** it further to make it more efficient.
2 The shell of the building has been completely **renovated / refurbished** and the interior decorators will be starting inside next week.
3 The Minister's inflammatory comments are just **exacerbating / aggravating** an already difficult situation. He should think before he opens his mouth next time.
4 The inspectors are going to be **evaluating / valuing** the performance of every teacher.
5 In Berkshire, a lorry carrying chemicals has crashed into a river and has **decayed / contaminated** the local water supply.
6 I set the school record for the 100m over eight years ago and it's never been **strengthened / bettered** to this day.
7 This new browser should **enhance / reinforce** everyone's experience online.
8 The number of school-leavers going on to university has **declined / devastated** since the government introduced tuition fees.
9 We must never let inflation **surpass / outclass** the three per cent mark again.
10 This accident has **wrecked / worsened** Dagli's chances of competing in the final.
11 Pop songs have **cheapened / worsened** the word 'love' so that it's meaningless nowadays.
12 The rock festival was fun, but it was marred by the organisation, which was a **chaos / shambles**.
13 The face in the picture is angelic, except for that tiny **blemish / flaw** just below the eye – can you see it? – that seems to be some kind of scar or birthmark.

B Circle the word which best matches each statement.

1 'I've never seen a more beautiful diamond!' **exquisite / sound**
2 'His honesty is the only feature about him that's positive.' **redeeming / ultimate**
3 'These metal railings are really old and brown.' **stale / rusty**
4 'It's just not good enough.' **invaluable / inadequate**
5 'The workmanship on this cabinet isn't very good.' **detrimental / shoddy**
6 'This CD-ROM drive isn't working properly.' **defective / detrimental**
7 'This apple's completely black.' **rotten / stale**
8 'This was the most important reason for us.' **optimum / prime**
9 'The job couldn't have been done without your help.' **exquisite / invaluable**
10 'The price seems reasonable to me. I'll take it.' **ultimate / satisfactory**
11 'This bread's not very fresh.' **rotten / stale**
12 'I think the government's measures are going to do quite a lot of damage.' **detrimental / defective**
13 'It's the most exciting experience you'll ever have!' **ultimate / optimum**
14 'I think it was a sensible decision.' **prime / sound**
15 'This is exactly what I need.' **ideal / prime**
16 'Excellent work. Well done!' **satisfactory / first-rate**
17 'Four is the right number of people for this project.' **ultimate / optimum**

Topic vocabulary: The arts

C **Write a word from the boxes in each gap.**

I haven't read Susan Bashworth's latest yet but I've heard it's very good. It became a **(1)** ..... within weeks of being published. I'm actually waiting for it to come out in **(2)** ..... before I get it.

bestseller • paperback

I've learnt all my **(3)** ..... for the play, which was easy, but we have to sing a song at the end and I'm just no good at remembering **(4)** .....

lines • lyrics

The school orchestra's giving a **(5)** ..... tonight which sounds quite interesting. They've got a guest conductor who's quite famous. Apparently, he's written the **(6)** ..... for a number of movies.

recital • score

We went to that **(7)** ..... of Lewis' paintings at the Granchester Museum last week. It was very good. We got chatting to the **(8)** ....., who told us a very interesting story about one picture ...

curator • retrospective

He told us that someone had found it in their attic, thought it was **(9)** ..... and so gave it to a neighbour. In fact, it turned out to be **(10)** .....!

priceless • worthless

One of the **(11)** ..... I'd love to do is restoring damaged or faded **(12)** ..... of art. It must be really satisfying seeing an old painting come to life again.

jobs • works

D **Complete using the words in the box in the correct form. There is one word you will not need.**

abstract • auction • audition • fine • installation • item • masterpiece • period • sketch

An alternative to galleries

When most of us think of works of art, we tend to think of pieces in galleries, whether they be famous **(1)** ..... (such as da Vinci's *Mona Lisa*) hanging on the wall, or bizarre **(2)** ..... (such as a pile of bricks with a red shoe on top).

Certainly, galleries are one of the main ways in which people can view art. Another way is to go to a/an **(3)** ..... . You don't have to be rich to attend (entrance is usually free), although if you're going to bid for a Van Gogh, you'd better take your bank details with you.

They're actually a great way to learn about art, because the catalogue gives detailed information about each piece, and there's often more variety than in a gallery. On any one day, there may be **(4)** ..... in pencil (artists generally do these before painting the actual picture), **(5)** ..... art (which includes sculptures and ceramics as well as paintings), collector's **(6)** ..... (anything from broomsticks to postcards), **(7)** ..... paintings (the catalogue will help you work out what the artist was trying to express) and even **(8)** ..... furniture.

Phrasal verbs

E **Write one word in each gap so the second sentence has a similar meaning to the first sentence.**

1 You'll have to improve your general knowledge before you go on that quiz show.
You'll have to ..... up on your general knowledge before you go on that quiz show.

2 The car was so badly damaged it had to be destroyed.
The car was so badly damaged it had to be ..... off.

3 One of the poems is particularly noteworthy due to its interesting use of imagery.
One of the poems particularly ..... out due to its interesting use of imagery.

4 If attendance doesn't improve soon, the play will probably have to close.
If attendance doesn't ..... up soon, the play will probably have to close.

5 I've heard a new gallery has opened in St Ives, so I'm going to see what it's like.
I've heard a new gallery has opened in St Ives, so I'm going to ..... it out.

6 Susan only just passed her history of art course.
Susan ..... through her history of art course.

7 The photo's got a couple of marks on it, so I'll scan it and make it look better with some software I've got.
The photo's got a couple of marks on it, so I'll scan it and ..... it up with some software I've got.

8 On the show today, we're going to completely change the look of the Simpsons' spare bedroom.
On the show today, we're going to completely ..... over the Simpsons' spare bedroom.

F **If a word is in the wrong sentence, write the correct word on the line. If it is correct, put a tick.**

1 The party was a bit boring to start with but everyone **livened** up when Rod got out his guitar. .....

2 I'm not very pleased with this drawing actually as I think I've **papered** up the perspective a little.
.....

3 I've only **wasted** this up for now – I won't be able to fix it properly until we get home. .....

4 Julie and Simone have **messed** over their differences while they get their business set up, but I'm sure they'll start arguing again pretty soon. .....

5 The Prime Minister responded that it was the previous administration which had **patched** the film industry down.
.....

6 Luckily, the weather **brightened** up in the afternoon so we were able to hold the reception outside after all.
.....

7 As kids, we always **ran** ourselves up when our grandparents came to visit. .....

8 The holiday at the health farm was awful. They only gave us a few vegetables every evening – I almost **smartened** away! .....

Phrases, patterns and collocations

G **Circle the correct word.**

1 I want this mess cleared up right now. Did I **make / do** myself clear?
2 It's **nice / good** and warm in here.
3 Off the top of my **brain / head**, I'd say this diamond's worth at least a million euros.
4 You're cutting it **fine / well**. The meeting starts in about two minutes.
5 To the **top / best** of my knowledge, there aren't any Picassos on the market at the moment.
6 That Ferrari Craig's just bought is **brand / model** new. It must have cost him a fortune!
7 Lee's his own worst **friend / enemy**. He complains he hasn't sold any of his paintings, but he won't show them to anyone.

8 There's been bad **blood / mood** between them ever since Trevor accused Charlton of sabotaging his opening night.
9 That's the last time I lie to a client for Mrs Richards. I'm not going to do her dirty **job / work** for her any more.
10 My mum's got organising her Christmas card list **round / down** to a fine art.

H **For each question, write one word which can be used in all three sentences.**

1 The caterers didn't turn up and the guest of honour was late so we had to make the ..... of a rather disastrous situation.
I know you're not very keen on art, but just do your ..... in the exam.
I didn't get the job in the end, but it's probably for the ..... .

2 I'm afraid we're ..... out of that CD.
As soon as I get out of prison, I'm determined to make a ..... start.
And now, ... from their blockbuster tour of the USA, here's ... *The Goldsmiths*!

3 She wants to make a ..... break and leave the publishing industry completely.
The doctors have given me a completely ..... bill of health.
This term, you all start again with a ..... sheet, so I won't hold anything you did wrong last term against you.

4 Is long hair back in ..... ?
I actually don't know much about that ..... of architecture.
If I was a rock star, I'd make sure I was treated with ..... wherever I went.

5 I bumped into an ..... flame of mine in Woolworth's this morning.
Dave's an ..... hand when it comes to doing the carnival disco – he's been doing it for years.
I'm afraid we're going to have to consider putting Mum in an ..... people's home.

6 They think I'm stupid but I'm not going to let them get the ..... of me.
We could stay at a hotel near the festival or, ... yet, camp in the grounds.
Yes, I'm certainly all the ..... for two weeks in the sun.

I **Write one word in each gap.**

Contemporary Art

There is a widely held view that artistic standards have got (**1**) ..... over the last 100 years or so and that contemporary art is (**2**) ..... a bad way, the clichéd response being 'my three-year-old child could have done better than that'. Yet many pieces sell for millions of dollars within the art world. How can we get to the (**3**) ..... of this seeming contradiction?
Those new (**4**) ..... contemporary art should be forgiven for this kind of response, but it is largely a matter of their ignorance rather than the reality. What needs to be (**5**) ..... clear is that contemporary art is at the cutting edge; painting a lifelike picture of a racehorse is no longer an option for an artist attempting to break new ground. Were contemporary artists to produce pictures like this, we would actually have the (**6**) ..... of all worlds – a stagnant and backward-looking artistic tradition.
Having said that, some contemporary art is of poor (**7**) ..... , but that's true of every art (**8**) ..... at any point in history. We can only decide that novels are great, for example, by having mediocre or bad novels to compare them to.
However, those (**9**) ..... the top of the contemporary art world are producing innovative and challenging pieces. At (**10**) ..... best, contemporary art is as exciting and productive as it's possible for art to be.
There is, of course, a (**11**) ..... line between quality contemporary art and pseudo-art. Abstract pictures produced by cats, for example, have no real place in the contemporary art world. They merely relieve the gullible and the ignorant of their money.

Idioms

J **Complete using the words in the box.**

edge • fuel • heel • line • par • pride • show • sight • top • whistle • word • world

1 *Soccer Maestro* is undoubtedly the last ..... in online football simulation games at the moment.
2 The picture that takes ..... of place on our mantelpiece, though, is the one of our granddaughter graduating.
3 You're a ..... for sore eyes, Claire! Thank goodness you're here – we desperately need your input.
4 Jean Paul is clearly a very talented designer. His one Achilles' ..... , however, may be his lack of business sense.
5 The buffet at the party was out of this ..... ! I've never tasted such exquisite strawberries.
6 Amis' new novel is slightly below ..... for a writer of his stature; I was a little disappointed.
7 All the bands were fantastic, but *The Editors* and *Franz Ferdinand* really stole the ..... .
8 I'm happy to simplify things for the readers, but I draw the ..... at telling them blatant untruths.
9 I think the media's response has been a little over the ..... – it's only a TV programme, after all.
10 Recent allegations in the press about price-fixing at the auction house have only added ..... to the fire regarding speculation about Dotheby's future.
11 I've spent the whole morning vacuuming the inside of the car. It's now clean as a ..... .
12 The Gordon Gallery clearly has the ..... over other modern art galleries; they have the largest collection, and the largest budget to spend on acquiring new pieces.

Word formation

K **Use the word given in capitals to form a word that fits in the space.**

1 Well, she did study ..... at Oxford, so it's hardly surprising she knows Latin and Ancient Greek. **CLASS**
2 *The Pet Shop Boys'* sound is ..... and unique. **IMITATE**
3 What this painting says to me is that we live in a world of ..... and despair. **DESTROY**
4 I've got enormous ..... for Ben; he's achieved such a lot in such a short space of time. **ADMIRE**
5 The main reason I believe children shouldn't be exposed to violence on TV is that they're so ..... at that age. **IMPRESS**
6 I'm a bit of a ..... , so I can spend all day agonising over which choice of two words to use. **PERFECT**
7 Maybe I am an ..... ; but what's wrong with wanting every human being to have access to clean drinking water? **IDEAL**
8 I've read that many performers suffered feelings of ..... as children. **ADEQUATE**
9 I don't know how ..... it would be to get some of these old postcards valued. **WORTH**
10 We'll find out how much the jewellery's worth at the ..... next Thursday. **VALUE**
11 Now the government's ..... the papers, we can find out what really happened. **CLASS**
12 Being director of the National Gallery is an ..... responsibility but thankfully I have a number of highly experienced experts to help me. **AWE**
13 With her experience as both an actor and a director, Tabitha is a very ..... successor to Albert Weeks as Chairperson of the National Theatre. **WORTH**
14 There were some very interesting clay ..... dating from the third century BC at the museum. **ART**

15 Stage fright is an understatement! Performing on stage for the first time was the most ..... experience I've ever had. **TERROR**

16 Don't throw away consumer packaging. Most of it's ..... if you use a little creativity. **USE**

17 There's a ..... difference between photography and still-life drawing. **QUALITY**

L **Use the word given in capitals to form a word that fits in the space.**

The working world of: Jacob Lawson

This week we look at the working life of Jacob Lawson, who buys and sells items on Internet auction sites.

In the old days, before the Internet, I had to trawl through hundreds of (**1**) ..... (**CLASS**) ads each week and go to car boot sales at the weekend. Auction sites like eBay, though, are extremely (**2**) ..... (**IMPRESS**) and a great (**3**) ..... (**IMPROVE**). It's just (**4**) ..... (**TERROR**) what you can do at the click of a button. I love it!

I generally buy and sell (**5**) ..... (**COLLECT**) items. These could be anything – from carriage clocks to knives and forks to plastic (**6**) ..... (**ART**) flowers. (**7**) ..... (**COLLECT**) are interested in the strangest things – and there's always money to be made. The best money comes from items that are in very good condition – often because they're (**8**) ..... (**USE**) and still in their packaging, but there's also a market for things like second-hand pottery or glassware that might have (**9**) ..... (**PERFECT**).

I'm quite successful. One of my (**10**) ..... (**STRONG**) is that I've got a very good rating on most of these sites – people I've sold to have given me very good reviews, so new customers trust me. I'm also good at spotting what's (**11**) ..... (**VALUE**) and what's completely (**12**) ..... (**WORTH**). For example, here's a pair of (**13**) ..... (**MATCH**) earrings. The description says they're diamond, but if you click on the picture, a trained eye like mine can tell immediately they're (**14**) ..... (**IMITATE**). Diamond's basically (**15**) ..... (**DESTROY**), you see, and these have got damage marks on them. So I won't be buying them. Ideally, it's better to actually see the (**16**) ..... (**GOOD**) you're buying before you purchase them, but these auction sites have pretty good policies if you're not satisfied with your purchase, and I've never had any problems.

M **The prefix *in-* can often mean 'not' or 'no'. However, in words such as *invaluable*, *in-* does not mean 'not' or 'no'. Tick the words where it means 'not' or 'no'. Put a cross next to the words where it doesn't.**

1 The **inbound** flight from Chicago has been delayed due to bad weather. .....

2 I really do value my **independence**. .....

3 The whole family was **infamous** round here for their antisocial behaviour. .....

4 I left the organisation eventually because of all the **infighting**. .....

5 This material is **inflammable**, isn't it? .....

6 What an **ingenious** idea. .....

7 The place will soon be **inhabitable**, won't it? .....

8 The whole area feels very **inhospitable**. .....

9 The situation is **intolerable**. .....

10 She was charged with being disorderly and **intoxicated**. .....